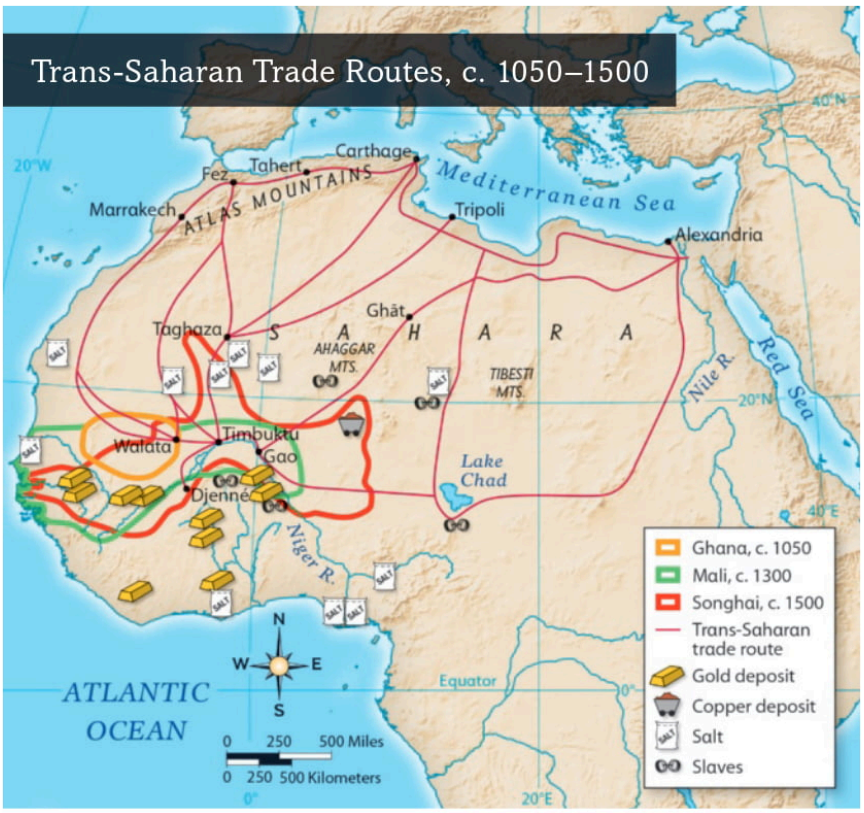
3.1 The Kingdom of Ghana

After Arab traders reached West Africa during the 700s, they talked of a land where even the horses were draped in gold cloth. This was the land of Ghana, and for centuries it was the wealthiest kingdom in West Africa.

MAIN IDEA West Africa's location made it a major trade center, leading to the rise of the kingdom of Ghana and the spread of Islam.



GOLD AND SALT IN GHANA

To reach the golden land, the kingdom of Ghana in West Africa, traders had to cross the largest hot desert in the world, the **Sahara**. Covered in dunes, rippling sheets of sand, and rocky formations, the desert extends over an area a little smaller than the United States. South of the desert is a **steppe** region of West Africa called the Sahel. Steppes are flat grasslands with very few trees.

The Sahara could have easily isolated the lands south of it. Extreme heat and a lack of water made travel through the region difficult for humans. Travelers had to carry enough fresh water to last until the next **oasis**, one of those rare areas in the desert that contain freshwater sources.

People who traveled across the Sahara discovered that camels were well suited to the desert climate and could carry humans and goods long distances through the Sahara. Camels can survive traveling up to 100 miles without water, and they can carry heavy loads. Nomadic traders began to lead camel **caravans**, or groups of people traveling together. In their caravans, they carried goods on **trans-Saharan** trade routes between sub-Saharan Africa and northern Africa, which lay within reach of Europe and Southwest Asia. Market towns started to flourish where trading routes met.

Two kinds of goods dominated trans-Saharan trade: gold and salt. Gold was mined in the forests south of Ghana and was regularly used as a trade item. Salt, however, was not produced naturally in this area. People had to look north to the Sahara, which had an abundance of this valuable and essential nutrient. In fact, buildings in the Saharan trading town of Taghaza were constructed of salt blocks because that was the building material in largest supply.

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Salt Caravans
This desert caravan is carrying salt blocks through the Danakil Desert in Ethiopia. Caravans similar to this one carried salt across the Sahara from northern Africa to Ghana many centuries ago.

A POWERFUL KINGDOM

Gold and salt traders met in West Africa, with gold flowing north and salt moving south. Near the midway point, the **kingdom of Ghana** grew and profited from the rising economy as the king collected taxes on the import and export of goods.

By the ninth century, Ghana was rich and powerful and able to conquer nearby lands with its strong army. The kingdom was structured according to a feudal system, with many princes ruling over various parts of the kingdom on behalf of the king.

In addition to goods, traders from North Africa carried their Islamic faith. Islam was the dominant religion of much of southwestern Asia at this time. Rising Muslim empires in North Africa made efforts to **convert**, or change, the people of West Africa to Islam and take over Ghana's trade, which weakened the power of the kingdom's rulers.

These efforts were so successful that in the mid-11th century, a historian named al-Bakri from al-Andalus (now Spain) described Ghana's capital as consisting of two towns. One was home to Muslim traders. The other was the palace of the king. By 1100, Ghana had declined as a result of droughts and unrest, providing an opportunity for a new Muslim empire to take control of the region.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did Ghana's location help it become wealthy?
2. **INTERPRET MAPS** Identify two geographic features that the people of West Africa would have to travel through to trade with others.
3. **MAKE INFERENCES** Why did the movement of traders help spread the influence of Islam?

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